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- UAVs are expected to be available for mass consumption by the end of the next decade
- While globally, drones are used for aerial mapping extensively, India is still at a nascent stage

The CIA first used unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) over Afghanistan in 2000, and post the 2001 terror attacks in the USA drones have become a part of the US military. However, since then the consumption of drones has evolved considerably. From military to commercial sectors, drone technology is fast being adopted by individuals, corporates and governments.

In fact, experts are hopeful that the commercial use of drones will soon turn it into a booming sector, thus making these available for mass consumption. According to a report by Pricewaterhouse Cooper LLP last year, the global commercial market for drones is expected to reach US\$ 127 billion by the year 2020. Currently, the global commercial market for drones is at US\$ 2 billion. While this is something that will happen in the future, there are a few business opportunities

that have already caught the eye of drone enthusiasts.

UAV training

UAVs are expected to be available for mass consumption by the end of the next decade. With industries across the globe betting big on this technology, it has become imperative to create engineers who are professionals in operating UAVs. Thus, a lot of drone technology firms are venturing into the UAV training space, which will ultimately create demand for the technology. And with the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) expected to come up with a clear set of regulations for operating drones commercially, India is expected to witness a sharp rise in the number of drone enthusiasts. According to a report by 6Wresearch last year, the Indian UAV industry is projected to hit US\$ 421 million by 2021.

"Drone technology is the future,

but we cannot expect everyone to have access to auto-operated drones as these are very expensive. Hence, we need professionals who understand how to operate drones, their technicalities and features, among others," says Jagadeesh Chander Muniavel, director at Maavan Aeronautics, a drone training institute in Chennai.

Currently, the institute has more than 50 engineers training on the various aspects of operating a drone. The institute has courses in UAV design and manufacturing, flight dynamics, pilot training, autopilot training, aerial mapping and imagery. The initial cost (to set up an institute, which includes buying drones, rent among others) is estimated to be US\$ 38,000, with an additional investment of US\$ 30,000 to US\$ 40,000.

Across the globe, the biggest challenge continues to be the high prices of drones, which make it difficult for training institutes to impart hands-on